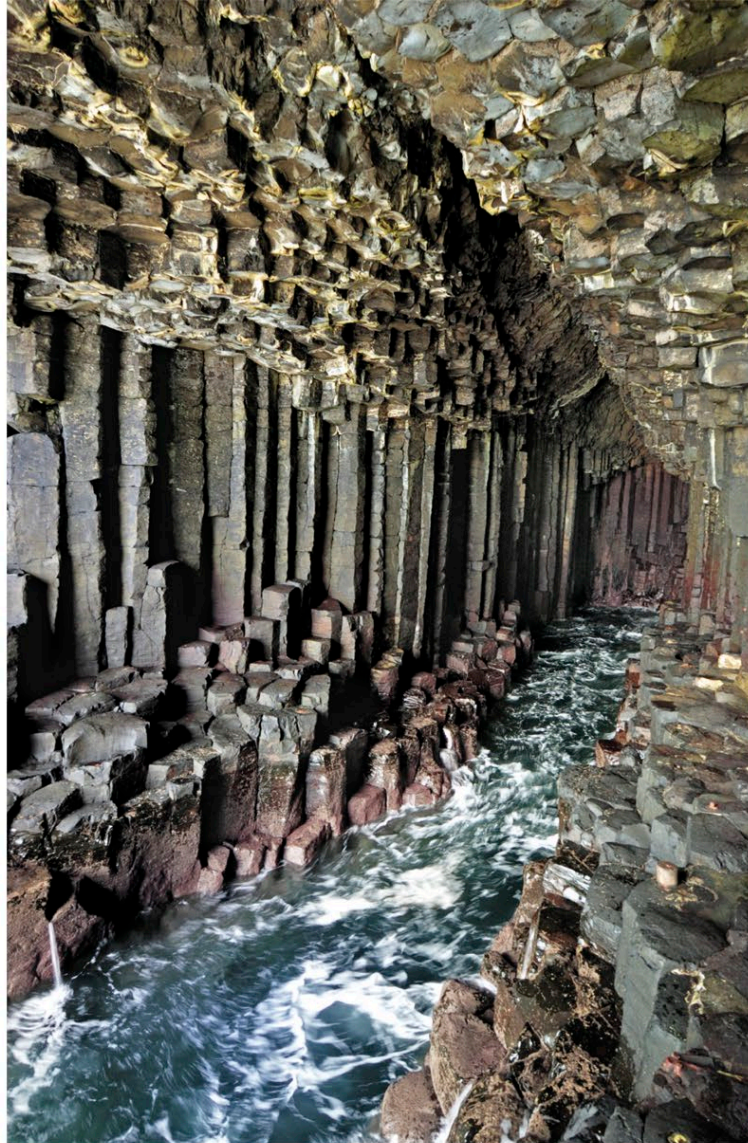


Fingal's Cave

An atmospheric sea cave on the uninhabited Scottish island of Staffa, known for its wonderful acoustics

Staffa is one of the Inner Hebridean islands off the west coast of Scotland, close to the much larger island of Mull. Its cave, named after the hero of an epic poem, is about 65 ft (20 m) high and extends about 200 ft (60 m) into the island.

In summer, local boating companies organize regular boat trips to Staffa. In calm conditions, visitors can explore Fingal's Cave, including its interior, via a walkway. The cave's size and arched roof, and the echoes of lapping waves, give it a special acoustic quality. The German composer Felix Mendelssohn, after visiting the cave in 1829, was so moved that he wrote an overture, "The Hebrides," in remembrance. This piece of music is now known as the "Fingal's Cave overture."

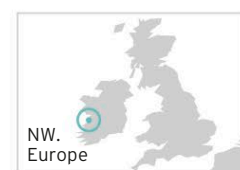


◁ HEXAGONAL FRAMING

The cave's arched entrance is framed by an array of hexagonal basalt columns. The sea covers the cave floor, with waves regularly washing and splashing in and out.

The Cliffs of Moher

An imposing procession of high, banded gray cliffs on the west coast of Ireland, home to tens of thousands of seabirds during the annual nesting season



The Cliffs of Moher extend along part of the coast of County Clare, Ireland, at the edge of a region called the Burren, which is dominated by karst topography (partially dissolved limestone). They take their name from an ancient fort called Moher, or Mothar, that once stood on Hag's Head, their southernmost point.

Ancient heights

The cliffs consist of layers of the sedimentary rocks shale and sandstone, which originally formed more than 300 million years ago. In parts, they rise more than 660 ft (200 m) above the Atlantic Ocean, and their tops offer fantastic views of various offshore islands and mountain ranges of western Ireland. These include the three Aran Islands in Galway Bay and the Maumturks mountain range in Connemara. Between April and July, more than 30,000 pairs of seabirds—including murrelets, razorbills, puffins, and cormorants—nest here, while numerous other species, including ravens, choughs, and peregrine falcons, can be seen all year round.



△ SUMMER VISITOR

From May to July, thousands of pairs of puffins, with their brightly colored beaks, nest on the cliffs.

◁ BANDED GIANTS

The cliffs wind in and out over a stretch of more than 5 miles (8 km). The banding pattern is due to color variation in the sedimentary rock layers.